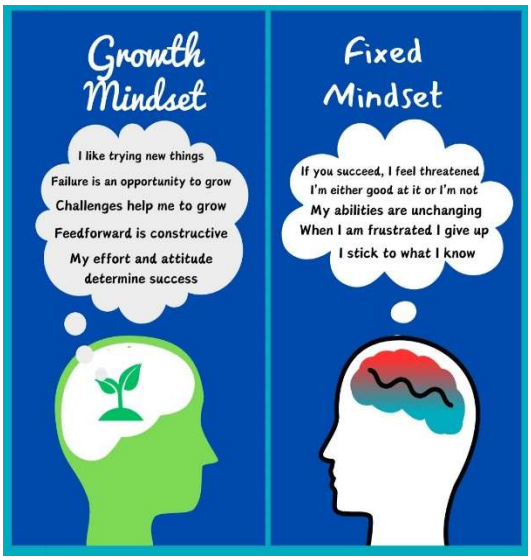
# Leadership Tool: Growth Mindset and Feedforward

If you think about your best teachers or the leaders you thought were most effective, chances are they believed in you and your growth. A growth mindset, which provides leaders and employees with an avenue to provide/receive feedback, is a psychological concept that highlights the malleability of one's abilities, behaviors, and intelligence. In other words, a growth mindset is, "…the belief that your basic qualities are things you can cultivate through your efforts, your strategies, and help from others" (Dweck, 2006, p. 7). The concept of a growth mindset contrasts with that of a fixed mindset, where individuals believe that basic qualities, talents, and intelligence are static, innate, and not changeable.




At its core, individuals with a growth mindset tend to believe improvement is possible and look for improvement in the actions of others over time. Growth mindset leaders are more willing to change their initial impressions of their employees and are more likely to engage in providing feedback or coaching to employee toward performance improvement because they believe people can grow from effort. The research, in several different fields, strongly supports the positive benefits of a growth mindset in leadership. For example, leaders who have a growth mindset were found to be more engaged at work and the relationship they had with their employees was stronger (Zingoni and Corey, 2016). Additionally, leaders who have a growth mindset were found to focus on learning and were more persistent/resilient in the face of setbacks, which in turn can have a positive outcome on performance (Zingoni and Corey, 2016).

In general, a growth mindset is developed through several different leadership practices. Leaders looking to utilize this mindset should embrace the following actions to both embrace a growth mindset in their actions and communicate to others how to develop their own growth mindset.

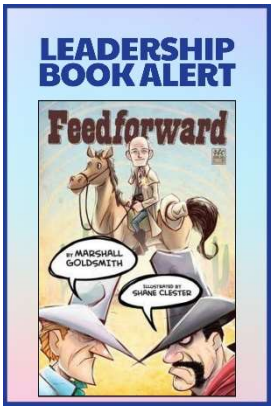
- **Praise the Process**: A leader who utilizes a growth mindset praise or provide constructive feedback on the process, not just the outcome. While most measurements of success are based on outcomes, meaning that most feedback (if it comes at all) is based on outcomes. However, outcomes are often influenced by more than effort and ability of the employee. The trick is to both appreciate the effort and learning that happens for employees, while also tying this effort and decision making into the feedback on the outcome. By remembering to address the process (in feedback, praise, rewards, etc.), leaders are establishing a culture that promotes growth, effort, and change.
- **Change Perception of Challenges**: As individuals, one important way we learn is by being stretched or working outside our comfort zone. By communicating to others that

challenges are not insurmountable obstacles but opportunities for personal and professional growth is critical to establish psychological safety, resilience and risk taking. By encouraging employees to take on new challenges and learn from these experiences, a leader will foster an environment of continuous improvement and innovation. In the end, employees will enhance their capabilities but also inspire other team members to adopt a similar mindset.

- **Encourage all types of Coaching and Feedback**: Another key practice in nurturing a growth mindset is for leaders to encourage and learn from all types of feedback. Leaders should especially view constructive feedback as a valuable source of insight, not as a personal attack. By opening channels for colleagues to provide different types of feedback, the leader can develop their areas of needed growth while also creating a more trusting and collaborative team environment. However, the key is for leaders to make sure that employees feel comfortable providing feedback, receiving the feedback gracefully, and using the feedback as a springboard for improvement.
- **Learning from Others**: Finally, fostering a growth mindset involves being willing to learn and develop from all experiences presented including from the success of others. One of the greatest resources of an organization is the people. Throughout the organization are individuals with unique strengths, abilities, and organizational knowledge. Those leaders who are most effective identify these qualities in others and learn from their success. Additionally, by both identifying and celebrating team members' achievements, while also understanding the strategies that led to their success, leaders can gain valuable insight that can be applied broadly within the organization. This not only helps in professional development but also promotes a culture of shared learning and mutual success.

## Feedforward

One useful tool in line with a growth mindset is "Feedforward." The feedforward method, originated by author and coaching practitioner *Marshall Goldsmith* (2002), is a forward-looking approach to providing feedback that focuses on future improvement rather than dwelling on past performance (feedback). By providing suggestions and guidance for future actions, leaders can help individuals enhance their skills, achieve their goals, and bring about positive change.




The feedforward method is particularly useful in promoting a growth mindset among individuals. Since the method focuses on future potential and improvement, leaders can encourage employees to see challenges to come as opportunities for growth, rather than spending time focusing on past setbacks. Leadership that dwells excessively on past mistakes or shortcomings can lead to a negative emotional impact and hinder progress. Instead, utilizing the information and experiences we have from the past to positively impact the future success of the employee creates a positive and constructive environment that focuses on the possibilities and potential for improvement. This mindset shift enhances resilience and fosters an overall culture of continuous learning within the team.

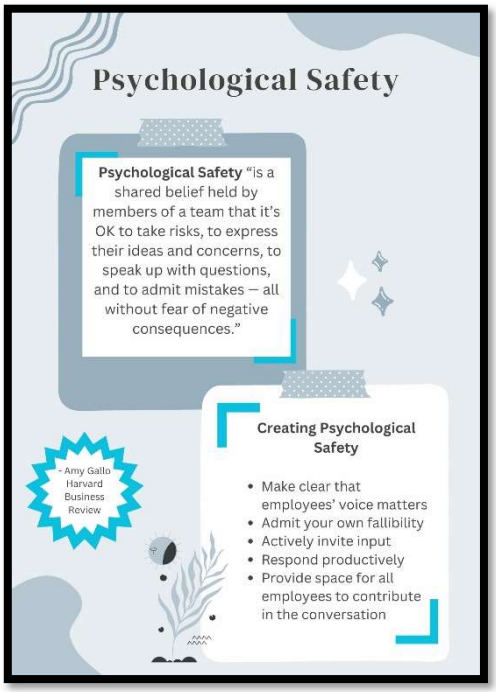
Additionally, the feedforward method can be particularly beneficial in a complex and dynamic work environment. In this context, both leaders and employees need to continually adapt to changes and keep pace with evolving challenges. Feedforward can bring together the leader and employee to collaborate on different strategies to navigate this uncertainty. Additionally, the feedforward process opens space for innovation to occur and provides an action plan to implement new solutions in the future.

Finally, in the feedforward process, space is provided for both the leader and the employee to identify and develop new skills and competencies. By identifying future goals and the actions needed to address a complex and dynamic work environment, individuals are given a clear path for development. The opportunity for both the leader and employee is identifying the skills or competencies that will be needed in the future to change the results of the past. Leaders are likely to find that this process not only helps employees to enhance their skills and competencies but also contributes to their overall sense of purpose and fulfillment at work.

The process of delivering feedforward is critical to the effectiveness of the method. The best practice steps, in the following section, can help leaders engage in the feedforward process maximizing their success. Each of the steps looks to provide feedforward in a manner that is specific, actionable, and supportive. By offering concrete suggestions and actionable steps, leaders enable individuals to envision their future success and take the necessary actions to achieve it. Furthermore, providing support and encouragement throughout the process can help individuals build confidence and maintain their motivation.

## Steps

To increase the effectiveness of utilizing the feedforward method, leaders should consider implementing the following steps. While the steps do not need to be used exactly in this order, the use of these best practices will help to ensure employees feel safe, encouraged, prepared, and ready to implement the suggestions moving forward.




### Step 1

In the first step of providing feedforward the leader should prepare themselves to create a psychologically safe environment based on a growth mindset. One helpful tip when creating a psychologically safe environment includes modeling vulnerability. Leaders who admit mistakes, acknowledge weaknesses, and share challenges, demonstrate that it is safe to engage in this type of open communication. Additionally, responding constructively to the reflection and acknowledgement of the employees' mistakes, weaknesses and challenges is necessary to encourage a culture of experimentation and learning, ultimately leading to innovation and development.

Moreover, leaders should look to incorporate a growth mindset right out of the gate. By emphasizing an individual's potential for growth and improvement, rather than focusing on the mistakes or weaknesses of the past, the individual will be more likely to self-reflect, engage in communicating solutions, and move toward future action. As a member of the team, it is in everyone's best interest that the individual feels inspired to embrace future challenges and to start working on the competencies or action plans needed to contribute to the team.

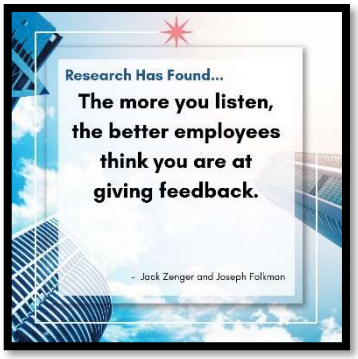
## Step 2

The second step in providing effective feedback is similar to providing any type of feedback, leaders should focus on setting up clear objectives by identifying goals and communicating expectations. What is different than other types of feedback (especially criticism or negative feedback of past actions) are the way the objectives for the feedback session are framed. The goals for the feedforward session should be future oriented. For example, instead of asking "why were you unable to make the 10 phone calls to customers this past week?" the leader would ask, "In the week coming up, what plans can we make (or actions can we take) to ensure you make 10 phone calls to customers?"

Placing the emphasis on the future orientation of the question will allow space for employees to reflect on the past to help inform the future without feeling anxiety, blame, or defensiveness. Additionally, by being specific and concrete about achieving a particular goal in the future, leaders can offer actionable recommendations that individuals can easily apply in their future endeavor. This forward-thinking clarity also helps the individual to clearly understand expectations based on desired changes and increases the likelihood they will implement these suggestions to have success.

## Step 3

Be an elephant, not a hippopotamus. Have very big ears and a small mouth. This is an opportunity for leaders to deeply engage in active listening in the feedforward process. Leaders can demonstrate genuine interest by asking clarifying questions, seeking to understand the individual's perspective, and positively reinforcing an employee's genuine reflection on development. By active listening you are much more likely to foster a sense of mutual respect, ensuring that the feedforward is tailored to the unique needs, aspirations, and opportunities of the individual.




Additionally, it is important to note that it is the leader, most of the time, that does not know why an employee did what they did. The employee knows why they put in extra time during the week. The employee knows why they did not have a chance to make the 10 phone calls. It is the leader, with a growth mindset, that needs to engage in active listening to learn why the employee engaged in work in this particular way. Having an open mind and listening will help the leader to identify possible solutions to recommend in the feedforward process that may be a change to the employee's actions but may also be a result of the environment or company.

## Step 4

After the active listening is completed, it is time to move into step four and create solutions/plans for change. Collaboratively, the leader and employee should propose possible solutions and/or actions plans to address situations that will be presented in the future. This is also a time in which the leader can identify and provide access to the resources, training, or mentorship opportunities employees may need to achieve their feedforward goals. It is important during the initial part of this discussion, a single "right" solution is not presented, but instead numerous solutions are suggested to address the challenge in the future. Once the pie of solutions is expanded, then the leader and employee can discuss which recommendations would work best for them in their particular context.

Two important tips in this step include keeping a positive tone and linking to larger goals. As the leader is addressing the areas of needed growth for the employee, it is important to remember to keep the conversation positive and constructive, fostering an environment of support and encouragement. It is easy to fall back into old ways of thinking and wanting to address past issues and make employees account for what happened. Remember, the goal of feedforward is growth, and this can only happen when an employee feels safe to reflect and acknowledge change is needed. Additionally, a valuable tip to engage employees in the solution identification and change process is to help them understand how their personal development aligns with the broader objectives of the team and organization. The more they see the relationship between their success and the team's success, the more likely they will be to engage in the changes recommended.

## Step 5

The final step, which is often overlooked by leaders but so essential for the feedforward method to work, is following up on the feedforward communication. While it is unlikely that the employee is to get every situation right during their first try or that every solution will fit perfectly to the context, it is important to follow up and discuss additional changes or recommendations. Additionally, follow up is an opportune time to celebrate progress. By acknowledging the progress the employee is making, it will continue to foster a culture of growth. Each time you need to provide feedforward in the future it will become easier because the trust and psychological safe environment has already been established.

Much like following up on the employee is important, it is also important for leaders to follow up on how they are using the feedforward process. If this is a new method for you as a leader, it would be important to ask those who engage in the process with you, how you can make changes in the future to make it a more effective process. This will certainly model the way for your employees as they get to see you asking for feedforward to improve your professional development. Additionally, as you find your unique style of leading feedforward, the more feedback you get the more likely you will continue to develop your ability to deliver high quality, effective feedback to your team.

## References

Dweck, C. S. (2006). *Mindset: The new psychology of success*. Random house.

Goldsmith, M. (2002). Try feedforward instead of feedback. *Leader to Leader*, *25*(Summer), 11-14.

Zingoni, M., & Corey, C. M. (2016). How mindset matters. *Journal of Personnel Psychology*.